

PUTTING DOWN ROOTS

A PHOTO ESSAY
BY MARGARET MORTON

MORE THAN any other art, landscape is positioned in impermanence. . . The truth is that all gardens are transitory . . . more like our lives, less like architecture: We build them to give an illusion of permanence.

Here in Margaret Morton's photographs of the gardens of the homeless in New York City, the reality of the transitory character of every landscape is evident. Ephemeral constructions — found objects arranged in found places — these gardens express a brief moment. Yet in many respects they speak of a desire for permanence or at least of an illusion of permanence. They are made and sustained under such uncertain circumstances that it is not known whether they will last one month, one week or one day. In spite of this uncertainty, however, they have been created with order and purpose . . .

Historical records have always favored the gardens of the wealthy and powerful, who can preserve or document their gardens . . . Gardens other than those of the

wealthy have rarely left a trace . . . While our book records the gardens of New York City inhabitants who, to say the least, have neither wealth nor leisure at their disposal, who have simply built gardens for themselves and have devoted time to them, it also presents a new way to consider the power of gardens. . .

It is possible that these gardens express only too well painful social conditions, their power lying both in the words which their makers use to describe them and in their visible form. But ultimately what the gardens show is a creative response to today's conditions . . .

We have purposely called these various exterior spaces gardens to express both the shift and the revitalization we think are taking place. The new gardens are not uninhabited green areas for viewing. They are spaces of active life, very small, not dominated by plants. They are filled with icons, toys, flags, and also the symbols of freedom and of nationality. At times, they are places of violence, danger and death; and they are always ephemeral.

— Diana Balmori



Formerly a parking lot with a chain-link fence, an empty plot of land on Tenth Street between Avenues B and C over a period of 10 months metamorphosed into a garden, now called 'Jardin de la 10 B-C.'



Pitts, a squatter who helped create a garden called 'Foetus' on a Lower East Side vacant lot, tends to his pond, above. The officially designated community garden below on Ninth Street and Avenue C centers on a lily pond backed by a trellis and benches.



A homeless man named Jimmy combined stones and tires, an armchair, a skid, some ailanthus and goldfish and a little wooden fence for his urban pond oasis, and he planted vegetables at the back of the Lower East Side plot. About a week after this picture was taken, Jimmy's garden was bulldozed, and he has disappeared from the area.



The large vacant lot on the Lower East Side known by its residents and tenement neighbors as 'Bushville' recalls the Hoovervilles of the 1930s. Plants have been nurtured by the planks. Guineo, at left, has lived on the site for two years; it's been settled for about four years. About 12 people, all from Puerto Rico, currently live in Bushville.